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Influencer marketing and Gen Z's purchase intentions: a structural equation modeling approach

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Introduction: Influencer marketing has become an important strategy for shaping consumer attitudes and purchase behavior, particularly among Generation Z consumers who are highly active on social media platforms. Although previous studies have examined influencer credibility and parasocial interaction separately, limited research has integrated influencer characteristics and content attributes within a unified framework, especially in emerging market contexts. This study investigates how influencer-related factors influence Generation Z consumers' purchase intention in India.
Methods: A quantitative cross-sectional research design was adopted. Data were collected from 370 Generation Z respondents from Tier-1 metropolitan cities in India who actively engage with influencer content on social media. Structural Equation Modeling (SEM) was employed to examine the relationships among influencer expertise, influencer passion, content quality, frequency of exposure, engagement, trust, perception, and purchase intention.
Results: The findings indicate that trust and perception significantly influence purchase intention and act as key mediating mechanisms. Influencer expertise positively affects trust, while content quality positively affects perception. Frequency of exposure negatively affects perception, suggesting diminishing effectiveness of repeated influencer content. Engagement did not significantly influence purchase intention and did not function as a mediator in this context.
Discussion: This study contributes to the influencer marketing literature by integrating Source Credibility Theory and Parasocial Interaction Theory within a single structural model and by providing empirical evidence from an emerging market context. The findings offer practical implications for marketers targeting Generation Z consumers by emphasizing the importance of influencer credibility, authenticity, and high-quality content over excessive exposure strategies.

KEYWORDS
consumer engagement, generation Z, influencer marketing, purchase intention, social media retailing, structural equation modeling, trust

1 Introduction

The proliferation of social media platforms has significantly transformed the marketing landscape, enabling digital content creators, commonly referred to as social media influencers, to play a central role in shaping consumer attitudes and purchase behavior. Despite the increasing adoption of influencer marketing strategies, the mechanisms through which influencer attributes and content characteristics translate into consumer purchase intention remain insufficiently understood, particularly among Generation Z consumers in emerging market contexts.

Generation Z, typically defined as individuals born between the mid-1990s and early 2010s, represents a digitally native cohort characterized by a strong preference for authenticity, peer-based recommendations, and interactive engagement (Fromm and Read, 2018; Williams et al., 2012). Social media platforms such as Instagram and YouTube have become dominant channels through which this cohort interacts with brands and influencers. Prior research suggests that Generation Z consumers are more likely to rely on influencers who demonstrate relatability, authenticity, and consistent value alignment, thereby enhancing the persuasive effectiveness of influencer marketing (Djafarova and Trofimenko, 2019). However, the extent to which specific influencer attributes and content-related factors jointly influence consumer decision-making processes remains underexplored. The effectiveness of influencer marketing can be explained through the integration of key theoretical perspectives. Source Credibility Theory posits that communicator characteristics, particularly expertise and trustworthiness, influence audience attitudes and behavioral responses (Ohanian, 1990). In this context, influencer expertise serves as a cognitive cue that enhances perceived reliability and reduces uncertainty in decision-making.

In contrast, Parasocial Interaction Theory explains how audiences develop perceived emotional relationships with media figures, resulting in feelings of familiarity, attachment, and social connection (Horton and Wohl, 1956). These relationships are particularly salient in social media environments, where influencers are often perceived as relatable peers. Together, these theories suggest that influencer attributes and content characteristics shape psychological responses, including engagement, trust, and perception, which subsequently influence purchase intention. Although prior studies have examined individual dimensions of influencer marketing, several research gaps remain. First, existing research often treats influencers as a homogeneous category and does not sufficiently distinguish between specific influencer attributes, such as expertise and passion, and content-related factors, such as content quality and exposure frequency. Second, while psychological constructs such as trust and engagement have been explored, limited studies have examined the simultaneous mediating roles of engagement, trust, and perception within a unified structural framework. Third, empirical evidence focusing on Generation Z consumers in the Indian context, particularly within Tier-1 metropolitan cities characterized by high levels of digital engagement, remains limited. Furthermore, lifestyle-oriented sectors such as fashion and food, where visual appeal and emotional connection are critical, have received relatively less attention in this context. To address these gaps, this study develops and empirically tests a theoretically grounded structural model that examines how influencer characteristics (expertise and passion) and content attributes (content quality and frequency of exposure) influence Generation Z consumers' purchase intention. The model further investigates the mediating roles of engagement, trust, and perception in explaining how influencer-related factors translate into consumer behavior. Accordingly, the study addresses the following research questions:

RQ1: How do influencer characteristics (expertise and passion) and content attributes (content quality and exposure frequency) influence Generation Z consumers' purchase intention?

RQ2: To what extent do engagement, trust, and perception mediate the relationship between influencer marketing factors and purchase intention?

This study adopts a quantitative cross-sectional research design and employs Structural Equation Modeling (SEM) to examine the relationships among the proposed constructs. By integrating Source Credibility Theory and Parasocial Interaction Theory within a unified framework, the study makes three key contributions. First, it provides a more nuanced understanding of influencer effectiveness by distinguishing between multiple influencer attributes and content characteristics. Second, it advances theoretical understanding by examining the differential mediating roles of engagement, trust, and perception. Third, it contributes empirical evidence from the Indian Generation Z context, thereby extending the applicability of existing theories to an emerging market setting. Overall, this study offers a theoretically integrated and empirically grounded explanation of how influencer marketing influences Generation Z consumers' purchase intentions, with particular relevance to visually driven sectors such as fashion.

2 Literature review

Understanding how Generation Z responds to influencer marketing requires an integrated examination of persuasion mechanisms and source-related cues within digital environments. The **Elaboration Likelihood Model (ELM)** (Petty and Cacioppo, 1986) provides a foundational framework for explaining how individuals process persuasive messages through either a central or peripheral route. In the context of social media, where users are frequently exposed to large volumes of content, Generation Z consumers are more likely to rely on **peripheral cues** rather than engage in extensive cognitive evaluation. These cues include influencer expertise, content quality, and frequency of exposure, which function as heuristic signals that shape attitudes and purchase intentions.

Building on this, Source Credibility Theory (SCT) emphasizes that communicator characteristics, particularly expertise and trustworthiness, play a critical role in influencing audience responses (Ohanian, 1990). Influencer expertise serves as a cognitive cue that enhances perceived reliability, while trustworthiness reduces uncertainty in decision-making. Prior research consistently demonstrates that higher levels of perceived credibility lead to stronger consumer trust and more favorable purchase intentions (Sokolova and Kefi, 2020). Thus,

credibility-related attributes operate as key drivers of persuasion in influencer marketing contexts.

Complementing this perspective, Parasocial Interaction Theory (PSI) explains how consumers develop perceived emotional relationships with influencers (Horton and Wohl, 1956). Through repeated exposure and personalized content, influencers create a sense of familiarity and intimacy, which fosters emotional attachment and engagement. For Generation Z consumers, who value relatability and authenticity, these parasocial relationships play a crucial role in shaping how influencer messages are interpreted and accepted.

2.1 Influencer expertise and passion

Influencer expertise and passion represent two distinct yet complementary dimensions of influencer effectiveness. Expertise refers to the perceived knowledge, competence, and experience of the influencer within a specific domain (Ohanian, 1990). Within the ELM framework, expertise functions as a peripheral cue that signals credibility and reduces perceived risk, thereby enhancing trust and influencing purchase intention.

In contrast, influencer passion reflects the emotional intensity and enthusiasm expressed in content creation. Passion contributes to perceived authenticity, which is particularly important for Generation Z consumers. Influencers who demonstrate genuine enthusiasm are more likely to be perceived as intrinsically motivated, thereby strengthening emotional connection and encouraging engagement (Audrezet et al., 2020). While expertise primarily operates through cognitive evaluation, passion functions through affective mechanisms, highlighting the dual role of logic and emotion in influencer persuasion.

2.2 Content quality and frequency of exposure

Content-related attributes play a significant role in shaping consumer responses to influencer marketing. Content quality refers to the perceived relevance, clarity, and aesthetic appeal of influencer-generated content (De Veirman et al., 2017). High-quality content enhances message processing and positively influences consumer evaluations, particularly through the central route of persuasion when users engage more deeply with content.

Frequency of exposure, grounded in the mere exposure effect (Zajonc, 1968), suggests that repeated exposure increases familiarity and liking. However, in digital environments characterized by content saturation, excessive exposure may lead to diminishing returns. For Generation Z consumers, frequent exposure may shift from reinforcing familiarity to generating fatigue, thereby negatively affecting perceptions of authenticity and credibility.

2.3 Engagement, trust, and perception as mediating mechanisms

Engagement, trust, and perception serve as key psychological mechanisms that explain how influencer attributes translate into consumer behavior.

Engagement refers to the degree of cognitive, emotional, and behavioral interaction with influencer content, including actions such as liking, commenting, and sharing (Brodie et al., 2013). While engagement reflects active interaction, prior research suggests that such interactions do not always translate into purchase-related outcomes, particularly among Generation Z users who may engage with content at a superficial level.

Trust represents the consumer's belief in the reliability, honesty, and credibility of the influencer (Ohanian, 1990; Sokolova and Kefi, 2020). Trust functions as a central mechanism that reduces perceived risk and enhances the persuasive impact of influencer recommendations. Influencers perceived as credible and transparent are more likely to influence purchase intention through trust-based processes.

Perception, in this study, refers to the consumer's evaluation of influencer authenticity, credibility, and relevance. This construct captures how followers interpret influencer content and assess its alignment with their values and expectations. From a Parasocial Interaction perspective, perceived authenticity plays a critical role in shaping these evaluations, as influencers who appear genuine and relatable are more likely to establish meaningful connections with their audience (Audrezet et al., 2020). Consequently, perception functions as a key mediator linking content-related factors to consumer responses.

2.4 Purchase intention

Purchase intention reflects an individual's conscious willingness to purchase a product or service based on available information and perceived value (Ajzen, 1991). In influencer marketing contexts, purchase intention is shaped by both cognitive evaluations (e.g., credibility and trust) and affective responses (e.g., emotional connection and authenticity). Prior studies consistently demonstrate that influencer credibility, trust, and perceived authenticity positively influence purchase intention, highlighting the importance of psychological mediators in consumer decision-making.

2.5 Path justification for the conceptual model

The proposed conceptual model integrates insights from the Elaboration Likelihood Model (ELM), Source Credibility Theory (SCT), and Parasocial Interaction Theory (PSI) to explain how influencer-related factors shape Generation Z consumers' purchase intention. Rather than assuming multiple simultaneous pathways, the model emphasizes dominant mediating mechanisms that are theoretically grounded and empirically supported.

2.5.1 Influencer expertise → trust → purchase intention

According to Source Credibility Theory, expertise is a fundamental determinant of perceived credibility (Ohanian, 1990). Influencers who demonstrate domain-specific knowledge and competence are more likely to be perceived as reliable, thereby enhancing consumer trust. Trust, in turn, reduces perceived risk

and increases the likelihood of accepting influencer recommendations, ultimately influencing purchase intention (Sokolova and Kefi, 2020). Thus, trust represents the primary mechanism through which expertise translates into consumer behavior.

2.5.2 Influencer passion → engagement → purchase intention

Influencer passion reflects emotional intensity and enthusiasm in content creation, which can stimulate audience interaction. Drawing on Parasocial Interaction Theory, emotionally expressive influencers foster a sense of connection that encourages followers to engage through likes, comments, and shares (Casaló et al., 2020). However, while engagement reflects active interaction, its influence on purchase intention may vary, as Generation Z consumers often engage with content without necessarily converting that engagement into purchasing behavior.

2.5.3 Influencer passion → trust → purchase intention

Beyond engagement, influencer passion may also signal authenticity. When influencers appear genuinely enthusiastic rather than commercially motivated, followers are more likely to perceive them as credible and trustworthy (Audrezet et al., 2020). This perceived authenticity strengthens trust, which subsequently influences purchase intention.

2.5.4 Content quality → perception → purchase intention

Content quality plays a central role in shaping how influencer messages are evaluated. Within the ELM framework, high-quality content enhances message processing and influences consumer judgments. In this study, perception defined as the consumer's evaluation of influencer authenticity, credibility, and relevance serves as the key mechanism through which content quality affects purchase intention. High-quality content strengthens positive perceptions, which in turn influence consumer decision-making.

2.5.5 Frequency of exposure → perception → purchase intention

While the mere exposure effect suggests that repeated exposure increases familiarity (Zajonc, 1968), excessive exposure in digital environments may lead to diminishing effectiveness. For Generation Z consumers, frequent exposure may negatively influence perception by reducing perceived authenticity and increasing content fatigue. Thus, perception serves as the primary pathway through which exposure frequency influences purchase intention.

3 Research model and hypothesis development

Drawing on the Elaboration Likelihood Model, Source Credibility Theory, and Parasocial Interaction Theory, the present study proposes a conceptual framework to explain how influencer related cues and content attributes shape Gen Z consumers' purchase intentions. Influencer expertise, passion, content quality, and frequency of exposure are expected to affect purchase intention both directly and indirectly through psychological mediators such as trust, engagement, and perception. By integrating these perspectives, the framework (Figure 1) explains how Gen Z consumers cognitively evaluate influencer messages and emotionally connect with influencers on social media platform.

3.1 Hypotheses formulation

This study develops a theoretically grounded conceptual framework that explicates the direct and indirect effects of influencer and content attributes on purchase intention. Drawing on the Elaboration Likelihood Model (ELM), influencer expertise, content quality, and frequency of exposure are conceptualized as peripheral cues that shape consumer attitudes. Source Credibility Theory (SCT) grounds the relationships between expertise, trust, and purchase intention, while Parasocial Interaction Theory (PSI) explains how passion, engagement, and perception mediate influencer effectiveness among Generation Z consumers.

3.1.1 Engagement → purchase intention

Engagement reflects the degree of cognitive, emotional, and behavioral interaction with influencer content. Prior research suggests that engagement enhances familiarity, perceived social proof, and emotional attachment, which may strengthen consumer responses to influencer recommendations (Schivinski et al., 2016). However, emerging evidence indicates that such interactions may remain superficial, particularly among Generation Z consumers, and may not necessarily translate into purchase intention (Lou and Yuan, 2019).

H1: Engagement with influencer content is positively related to Generation Z consumers' purchase intention.

3.1.2 Trust → purchase intention

Trust represents a critical determinant of persuasion in digital environments. According to Source Credibility Theory, consumers are more likely to accept recommendations from sources perceived as reliable and credible (Ohanian, 1990). Trust reduces perceived risk and increases confidence in purchase decisions, thereby strengthening purchase intention (Sokolova and Kefi, 2020).

H2: Trust in influencers is positively related to Generation Z consumers' purchase intention.

3.1.3 Perception → purchase intention

Perception, defined as the consumer's evaluation of influencer authenticity, credibility, and relevance, plays a central role in

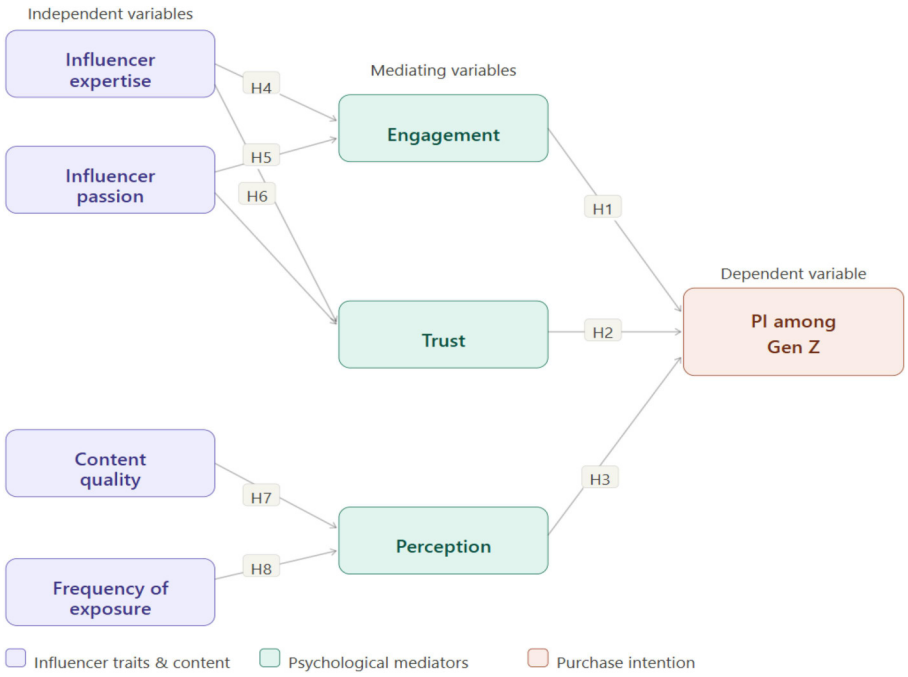


FIGURE 1
Framework illustrating Key constructs and relationships.

shaping responses to influencer content. From a parasocial interaction perspective, perceived authenticity enhances emotional connection and influences how consumers interpret influencer messages. Positive perceptions are therefore expected to strengthen purchase intention.

H3: Perception of influencer authenticity, credibility, and relevance is positively related to Generation Z consumers' purchase intention.

3.1.4 Influencer expertise → trust

Influencer expertise functions as a key dimension of credibility. According to Source Credibility Theory, higher levels of perceived expertise enhance trust in the communicator, as consumers rely on knowledgeable sources when evaluating product information (Ohanian, 1990).

H4: Influencer expertise positively influences trust in influencers.

3.1.5 Influencer passion → engagement

Influencer passion reflects emotional expressiveness and enthusiasm, which can stimulate audience interaction. Drawing on Parasocial Interaction Theory, emotionally expressive content fosters perceived closeness and encourages engagement behaviors such as liking, commenting, and sharing (Casaló et al., 2020).

H5: Influencer passion positively influences engagement with influencer content.

3.1.6 Influencer passion → trust

In addition to driving engagement, influencer passion signals authenticity. When influencers appear genuinely enthusiastic, they are more likely to be perceived as intrinsically motivated, which enhances trust (Audrezet et al., 2020).

H6: Influencer passion positively influences trust in influencers.

3.1.7 Content quality → perception

Content quality enhances how consumers evaluate influencer messages. Within the ELM framework, high-quality content strengthens message processing and shapes consumer judgments. In this study, content quality is expected to enhance perception, defined as the evaluation of authenticity, credibility, and relevance.

H7: Content quality positively influences consumer perception of influencer authenticity, credibility, and relevance.

3.1.8 Frequency of exposure → perception

The mere exposure effect suggests that repeated exposure increases familiarity (Zajonc, 1968). However, excessive exposure may reduce perceived authenticity and lead to content fatigue. Therefore, exposure frequency is expected to influence perception, potentially in a negative direction.

H8: Frequency of exposure influences consumer perception of influencer authenticity, credibility, and relevance.

3.1.9 Extended mediator links

Expertise enhances trust (Ohanian, 1990) and trust strengthens purchase intention (Lou and Yuan, 2019), trust is theoretically positioned as the dominant mediating mechanism in this pathway, consistent with Source Credibility Theory.

H9: Trust mediates the relationship between influencer expertise and purchase intention.

Since influencer passion drives engagement (Casaló et al., 2020) and engagement is expected to influence purchase intention (Schivinski et al., 2016), engagement serves as the primary mediating pathway through which passion affects consumer behavior.

H10: Engagement mediates the relationship between influencer passion and purchase intention."

Content quality shapes consumer perception (Jin et al., 2019) and perception drives purchase intention (Djafarova and Trofimenko, 2019), perception is identified as the key mediating mechanism linking content quality to consumer decisions.

H11: Perception mediates the relationship between content quality and purchase intention.

Frequency of exposure influences consumer perception (Lee and Watkins, 2016) and perception drives purchase intention, perception mediates the relationship between exposure frequency and purchase intention, particularly in contexts characterized by content fatigue (Reinikainen et al., 2020).

H12: Perception mediates the relationship between frequency of exposure and purchase intention.

4 Research methodology

4.1 Research design

This study employed a quantitative cross-sectional survey design to examine the relationships between influencer-related factors and Generation Z consumers' purchase intention. A structured questionnaire was used to measure the latent constructs included in the proposed model. The cross-sectional design enables the analysis of relationships among variables at a single point in time; however, it does not permit causal inference.

4.2 Sample and data collection

A purposive non-probability sampling technique was employed to select respondents who actively engage with influencer content on social media platforms such as Instagram and YouTube. This approach is appropriate for targeting digitally active Generation Z users, who constitute the primary population of interest in influencer marketing research.

However, the use of purposive sampling introduces limitations related to external validity and generalizability. The sample is restricted to respondents from Tier-1 metropolitan cities in India, who are likely to exhibit higher levels of digital literacy and social media engagement than the broader population. Therefore, the findings should be interpreted as context-specific and may not be generalizable to Generation Z consumers in rural areas, smaller cities, or different cultural settings. While this sampling approach enhances contextual relevance, it does not ensure representativeness of the overall population. Future research may adopt probability-based sampling techniques or include more diverse geographic segments to improve generalizability.

The final sample comprised 370 usable responses, which is considered adequate for the complexity of the proposed structural model. In line with Hair et al. (2019), SEM studies with models of moderate complexity generally require a minimum of 200 observations. Furthermore, applying the commonly recommended ratio of at least ten observations per estimated parameter, and considering that the model comprises eight latent constructs measured by 24 observed indicators, the sample size of 370 exceeds the minimum requirements for reliable parameter estimation, thereby providing adequate statistical power for the proposed structural model.

In addition to direct path estimation, indirect effects were formally assessed to evaluate the proposed mediation relationships. Bootstrapping procedures were employed using AMOS 24, with 5,000 bootstrap resamples generated and bias-corrected confidence intervals computed at the 95% confidence level, consistent with contemporary recommendations for indirect effect estimation in SEM-based research (Hair et al., 2019; Preacher and Hayes, 2008). A mediation effect is considered statistically significant when the bootstrapped confidence interval does not include zero.

4.3 Instrument development

The measurement instrument (Table 1) was developed using items adapted from previously validated scales in the influencer marketing and consumer behavior literature. All constructs were measured using a five-point Likert scale ranging from 1 (strongly disagree) to 5 (strongly agree). Minor modifications were made to item wording to ensure contextual relevance to influencer marketing among Generation Z consumers in India. The use of established scales supports the content validity and reliability of the measurement instrument.

4.4 Pilot study

A pilot study was conducted with 87 respondents drawn from the targeted audience (digitally active Generation Z users, who constitute the primary population of interest in influencer marketing research) to evaluate the reliability and validity of the measurement instrument prior to the main data collection. The primary purpose of the pilot study was twofold: to assess the psychometric properties of the scales and to identify any items

TABLE 1 Instrument development.

Construct	Code	Measurement items	Source
Influencer expertise (IFE)	IFE1	The influencer is highly knowledgeable in their domain	Ohanian (1990); Casaló et al. (2020)
	IFE2	The influencer provides reliable and accurate information	
	IFE3	The influencer is experienced in food/fashion content	
Influencer passion (IFP)	IFP1	The influencer shows genuine passion for what they promote	Lou and Yuan (2019)
	IFP2	The influencer appears enthusiastic and invested in their content	
	IFP3	The influencer seems emotionally connected to their niche	
Content Quality (CQ)	CQ1	The content is visually appealing and professionally produced	Hwang and Zhang (2018); Djafarova and Trofimenko (2019)
	CQ2	The influencer shares high-quality and creative posts	
	CQ3	The content is consistent and relevant to my interests	
Frequency of exposure (FOE)	FOE1	I frequently see this influencers posts on my feed	Reinikainen et al. (2020)
	FOE2	The influencer posts content regularly	
	FOE3	I often engage with the influencers posts (likes, comments, shares)	
Engagement (ENG)	ENG1	I like, comment, or share this influencers content regularly	Jin et al. (2019)
	ENG2	I actively follow updates from this influencer	
	ENG3	I enjoy interacting with the influencers content	
Trust (TT)	TT1	I trust the information shared by this influencer	Ohanian (1990); Sokolova and Kefi (2020)
	TT2	The influencer appears honest and transparent	
	TT3	I believe this influencer has my best interests in mind	
Perception (PP)	PP1	I can relate to this influencer personally	Audrezet et al. (2020)
	PP2	The influencer reflects values and lifestyle similar to mine	
	PP3	I view the influencer as authentic and genuine	
Purchase intention (PI)	PI1	I would consider buying a product recommended by this influencer	Sokolova and Kefi (2020)
	PI2	I have already bought products based on this influencers suggestion	
	PI3	I am likely to try a product if this influencer promotes it	

that may hinder respondent comprehension or reduce measurement accuracy.

Following pilot testing ($n = 87$), three items (IFE2, PP1, CQ3) were rephrased for clarity, as their corrected item-total correlations ranged from 0.45 to 0.62, falling below the recommended threshold of 0.50 (Nunnally, 1978). The revisions were made in consultation with the relevant literature and reviewed by subject matter experts to ensure content validity was preserved throughout the refinement process.

Following these modifications, the refined instrument demonstrated excellent psychometric properties across all eight constructs. Cronbach's alpha values ranged from 0.921 to 0.937, all exceeding the recommended threshold of 0.70 (Nunnally, 1978). Composite reliability (CR) values ranged from 0.920 to 0.945, and average variance extracted (AVE) values ranged from 0.794 to 0.849, surpassing their respective benchmarks of 0.70 and 0.50 (Fornell and Larcker, 1981). Furthermore, maximum shared variance (MSV) values were uniformly lower than their corresponding AVE values for all constructs, confirming discriminant validity. The refined instrument was subsequently employed in the main data collection without further modification.

4.5 Reliability and validity assessment

The internal consistency and construct reliability of the measurement model were to be assessed before running factor analysis. ["Convergent validity was assessed by evaluating Cronbach's Alpha, Composite Reliability (CR), and Average Variance Extracted (AVE) (refer Table 2). Discriminant validity was assessed by Fornell–Larcker criterion] which entails comparing the square root of each construct's AVE with its correlations with other constructs.

From above the table, the reliability and convergent validity of the measurement model were assessed using standardized factor loadings, Cronbach's alpha, Composite Reliability (CR), and Average Variance Extracted (AVE). All standardized factor loadings exceeded the recommended threshold of 0.70, ranging from 0.868 to 0.924, indicating satisfactory to excellent indicator reliability across all constructs. Internal consistency was confirmed through Cronbach's alpha values ranging from 0.921 to 0.937, well above the recommended minimum of 0.70, confirming strong internal consistency of the measurement scales. Composite Reliability (CR) values ranged between 0.920 and 0.945, further supporting construct reliability. All CR values exceeded the recommended

TABLE 2 Measurement reliability and convergent validity.

Variables	Scale-items	Standradized Laten-factor loading	Cronbach's alpha	(CR) Composite Reliability	AVE (Average variance extracted)	Maximum shared variance
Perception	PP1	0.915	0.921	0.927	0.810	0. 325
	PP2	0.895				
	PP3	0.868				
Trust	TT1	0.893	0.932	0.929	0. 813	0. 355
	TT2	0.922				
	TT3	0.900				
Engagement	ENG1	0.920	0.922	0.926	0. 808	0. 008
	ENG2	0.885				
	ENG3	0.876				
Frequency of exposure	FOE1	0.914	0.936	0.940	0. 836	0. 019
	FOE2	0.897				
	FOE3	0.922				
Content quality	CQ1	0.893	0.924	0.928	0. 812	0. 325
	CQ2	0.919				
	CQ3	0.874				
Influencer passion	IFP1	0.895	0.927	0.927	0. 809	0. 126
	IFP2	0.922				
	IFP3	0.881				
Influencer expertise	IFE1	0.898	0.937	0.945	0. 849	0. 355
	IFE2	0.914				
	IFE3	0.924				
Purchase intention	PI1	0.902	0.921	0.920	0. 794	0. 325
	PI2	0.903				
	PI3	0.870				

threshold of 0.70, confirming that the constructs are measured reliably. Convergent validity was assessed using AVE values, which ranged from 0.794 to 0.849, surpassing the recommended threshold of 0.50 (Fornell and Larcker, 1981), indicating that a substantial proportion of variance in the observed variables is explained by their respective latent constructs. Furthermore, Maximum Shared Variance (MSV) values for all constructs were lower than their corresponding AVE values, providing additional support for discriminant validity. Overall, the measurement model demonstrates satisfactory to excellent reliability, convergent validity, and discriminant validity, confirming that all constructs are appropriate for subsequent structural model analysis.

Discriminant validity was assessed using the Fornell–Larcker criterion, which compares the square root of the Average Variance Extracted (AVE) for each construct with its inter-construct correlations (Fornell and Larcker, 1981). As presented in Table 3, the diagonal elements representing the square roots of AVE are consistently higher than the corresponding off-diagonal correlation coefficients across all construct pairs. The highest inter-construct correlation observed was between Trust and Influencer Expertise ($r = 0.596$), which remained substantially lower than the square root of AVE for both constructs (0.901 and 0.921, respectively). These results confirm that each construct shares more variance with its own indicators than with any other construct in the model, thereby establishing satisfactory discriminant validity. Collectively, the measurement model demonstrates adequate reliability, convergent validity, and discriminant validity, supporting the suitability of all constructs for subsequent structural analysis.

4.6 Exploratory analysis

Prior to conducting exploratory factor analysis, the suitability of the data was assessed using the Kaiser-Meyer-Olkin (KMO) (refer Table 4) measure of sampling adequacy and Bartlett's Test of Sphericity. The KMO value of 0.826 exceeds the recommended threshold of 0.60 (Kaiser, 1974), indicating that the correlation patterns among variables are sufficiently compact to support factor analysis. Bartlett's Test of Sphericity was statistically significant ($\chi^2 = 7584.412$, $df = 276$, $p < .001$), confirming that the correlation matrix is not an identity matrix and that meaningful factors can be extracted from the data.

Communality estimates (Table 5), derived using Principal Component Analysis, exceeded the recommended threshold of 0.50 for all items, ranging from 0.716 (PI3) to 0.899 (IFE1), indicating that the extracted factors adequately account for the

TABLE 3 Discriminant validity.

Construct	PP	TT	ENG	FOE	CQ	IFP	IFE	PI
PP	**0.900**							
TT	0.013	**0.901**						
ENG	−0.007	0.017	**0.899**					
FOE	−0.136	−0.007	−0.083	**0.914**				
CQ	0.570	−0.042	−0.051	−0.060	**0.901**			
IFP	−0.053	0.054	0.101	−0.005	−0.126	**0.899**		
IFE	0.006	0.596	0.085	0.044	0.037	−0.047	**0.921**	
PI	0.499	0.485	−0.017	−0.093	0.351	−0.011	0.406	**0.891**

Bold values shown on the diagonal indicate the square root of the average variance extracted (AVE), used to assess discriminant validity.

TABLE 4 "KMO and bartlett's test".

"KMO and Bartlett's Test"		
"Kaiser-Meyer-Olkin Measure of Sampling Adequacy"		.826
"Bartlett's Test of Sphericity"	Approximate-Chi-Square	7584.412
	df	276
	Sig.	.000

TABLE 5 Anti-image correlation & communality.

Communalities		"Anti-image correlation"	
Item/Questions	Extraction	Item/Questions	MSA
IFE1	0.899	IFE1	0.846
IFE2	0.893	IFE2	0.839
IFE3	0.878	IFE3	0867
IFP1	0.862	IFP1	0.767
IFP2	0.888	IFP2	0.725
IFP3	0.872	IFP3	0.763
CQ1	0.858	CQ1	0.842
CQ2	0.879	CQ2	0.821
CQ3	0.859	CQ3	0.833
FOE1	0.895	FOE1	0.755
FOE2	0.879	FOE2	0.769
FOE3	0.891	FOE3	0.754
ENG1	0.858	ENG1	0.767
ENG2	0.861	ENG2	0.759
ENG3	0.887	ENG3	0.729
TT1	0.805	TT1	0.872
TT2	0.841	TT2	0.855
TT3	0.832	TT3	0.872
PP1	0.753	PP1	0.888
PP2	0.769	PP2	0.850
PP3	0.757	PP3	0.799
PI1	0.726	PI1	0.897
PI2	0.737	PI2	0.865
PI3	0.716	PI3	0.852

Extraction Method: Principal Component Analysis.

variance in each item. Additionally, the anti-image correlation values, representing individual item-level measures of sampling adequacy (MSA), exceeded the recommended threshold of 0.70 for all items, ranging from 0.725 (IFP2) to 0.897 (PI1), confirming the suitability of each item for inclusion in the factor analysis.

Collectively, these results confirm that the dataset meets all prerequisites for exploratory factor analysis, supporting the subsequent extraction and interpretation of meaningful factor structures."

The rotated component matrix (Table 6) reveals a well-defined eight-factor structure, with each set of items loading strongly on their respective constructs. All factor loadings exceeded the recommended threshold of 0.70 (Hair et al., 2019), ranging from 0.742 to 0.955, indicating satisfactory to excellent item reliability and adequate representation of the underlying latent constructs. Although Purchase Intention items exhibited a comparatively wider loading range (0.742–0.955), all values remained above the accepted threshold, confirming acceptable item reliability for this construct.

Each construct — Perception, Trust, Influencer Expertise, Frequency of Exposure, Content Quality, Influencer Passion, Engagement, and Purchase Intention — loaded distinctly onto separate dimensions, with items exhibiting high loadings on a single factor and no significant cross-loadings observed. This pattern confirms a well-defined and stable factor structure with clear construct boundaries.

The consistent separation of constructs and high factor loadings provide satisfactory evidence of construct validity and confirm the proposed dimensionality of the measurement model. These results provide a sound empirical basis for proceeding to confirmatory factor analysis, wherein the eight-factor structure will be subjected to more rigorous model-based validation.

4.7 CFA model-fit summary

The CFA (Figure 2) results indicate that the measurement model demonstrates satisfactory to excellent fit across all evaluated indices, as summarized in Table 7.

TABLE 6 Loading factor in EFA.

"Rotated component matrix[a]"								
	Dimension							
	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8
IFE1			.896					
IFE2			.901					
IFE3			.876					
IFP1						.922		
IFP2						.937		
IFP3						.933		
CQ1					.885			
CQ2					.886			
CQ3					.885			
FOE1				.942				
FOE2				.935				
FOE3				.938				
ENG1							.922	
ENG2							.921	
ENG3							.939	
TT1		.850						
TT2		.873						
TT3		.876						
PP1	.809							
PP2	.816							
PP3	.811							
PI1								.742
PI2								.904
PI3								.955

Extraction Method -Principal Component Analysis.
Rotation Method -Varimax with Kaiser Normalization.
[a]Rotation converged in 8 iterations.

In terms of absolute fit, the chi-square to degrees of freedom ratio (CMIN/DF = 1.109) is well below the recommended threshold of 3.0, indicating an acceptable model fit. The Goodness-of-Fit Index (GFI=0.950) and Adjusted Goodness-of-Fit Index (AGFI = 0.932) both exceed the recommended threshold of 0.90, providing further support for adequate model fit.

With respect to incremental fit indices, the Normed Fit Index (NFI = 0.968), Comparative Fit Index (CFI = 0.997), and Tucker–Lewis Index (TLI = 0.996) all surpass the recommended threshold of 0.90, confirming strong incremental fit relative to the null model.

Regarding error-based fit, the Root Mean Square Error of Approximation (RMSEA = 0.017) falls well below the threshold of 0.05 for close fit and 0.08 for acceptable fit (Browne and Cudeck, 1992), indicating an exceptionally close fit of the model to the observed data. The PCLOSE value of 1.000 further confirms that the model fits the population covariance matrix well.

Collectively, these indices confirm that the measurement model achieves satisfactory to excellent goodness-of-fit, providing a sound empirical basis for proceeding to structural model analysis."

5 Statistical analysis and interpretation

Structural Equation Modeling (SEM) was employed to test the proposed theoretical relationships among the constructs. The analytical approach allows the simultaneous estimation of multiple relationships and provides an efficient means of assessing mediation effects. However, it should be noted that SEM, when applied to cross-sectional self-report data, identifies associations rather than causal effects. The directional paths in the model are derived from established theory and prior empirical findings, not from experimental manipulation. Accordingly, the results should be interpreted as evidence of theoretically grounded correlations rather than definitive causal relationships.

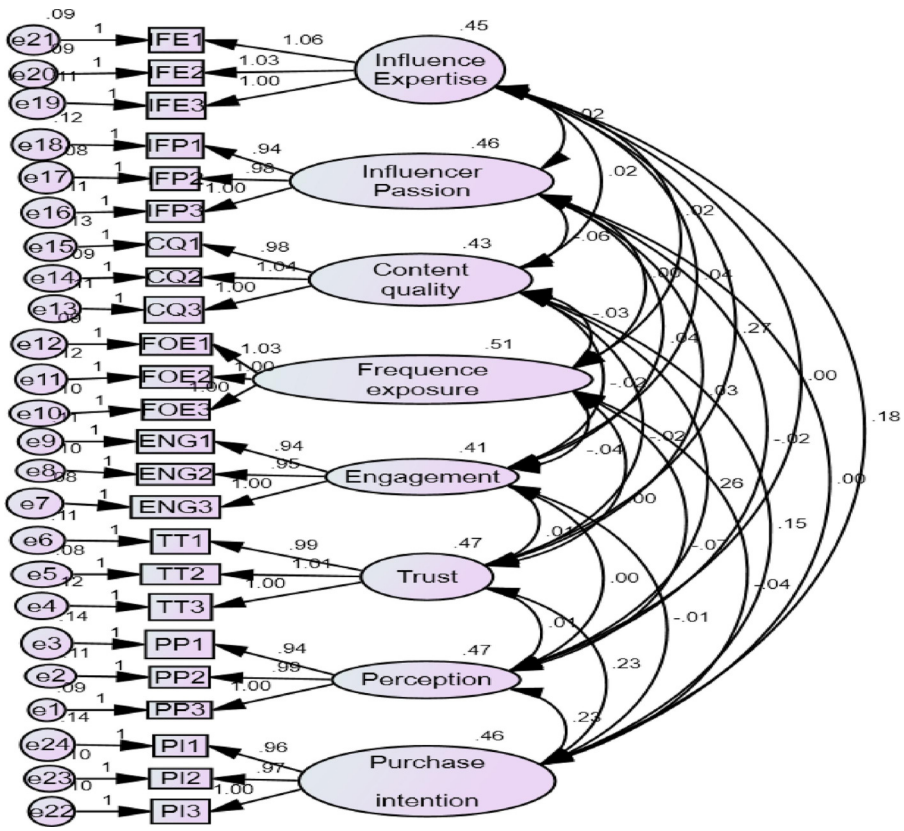


FIGURE 2
Final model CFA.

TABLE 7 CFA model-fit summary.

Fit Index	Recommended	Obtained value	Interpretation
CMIN/DF	<3	1.109	Excellent fit
GFI	>0.90	0.950	Good fit
AGFI	>0.90	0.932	Good fit
NFI	>0.90	0.968	Good fit
CFI	>0.90	0.997	Excellent fit
TLI	>0.90	0.996	Excellent fit
RMSEA	<0.08	0.017	Close fit
PCLOSE	>0.05	1.000	Strong support

5.1 Participants' demographic characteristics

As presented in Table 8, the sample comprised 370 Generation Z respondents residing in Tier-1 metropolitan cities in India. In terms of gender, 59.5% of respondents were female and 40.5% were male. The age distribution indicates that the majority of participants (83.8%) were between 22 and 28 years old, reflecting a mature segment of Generation Z likely to engage in independent purchase decision-making. With respect to educational background, 67.3% of respondents were undergraduates, indicating a relatively educated sample with sufficient digital literacy to engage meaningfully with influencer content. Regarding monthly income, the majority of respondents (67.9%) reported earnings between ₹10,000 and ₹30,000, consistent with the financial profile of students or early-career professionals. In terms of social media usage, 57.0% of respondents reported spending more than two hours daily on social media platforms, reflecting high levels of digital engagement. These demographic characteristics confirm the contextual relevance of the sample for examining influencer marketing effects among digitally engaged Generation Z consumers in India

TABLE 8 Demographic profile of respondents.

Variable	Category	Frequency	Percent	Cumulative percent	Total
Gender	Male	150	40.5%	40.5%	370
	Female	220	59.5%	100.0%	
Age	18–21	60	16.2%	16.2%	370
	22–25	151	40.8%	57.0%	
	26–28	159	43.0%	100.0%	
Education	High School	40	10.8%	10.8%	370
	Undergraduate	249	67.3%	78.1%	
	Postgraduate	26	7.0%	85.1%	
	Other	55	14.9%	100.0%	
Monthly income	Below ₹10,000	69	18.6%	18.6%	370
	₹10,000–₹20,000	112	30.3%	48.9%	
	₹20,000–₹30,000	139	37.6%	86.5%	
	₹30,000 & Above	50	13.5%	100.0%	
Social media usage	Less than 1 h	62	16.8%	16.8%	370
	1–2 h	97	26.2%	43.0%	
	2–4 h	143	38.6%	81.6%	
	4 + hours	68	18.4%	100.0%	

5.2 Influence of independent variables on purchase intention

Prior to estimating the full structural model, a direct effects model was examined to assess the isolated influence of each independent variable on Generation Z consumers' purchase intention. The model demonstrated satisfactory fit across all major indices (χ^2/df = 0.541, RMSEA = 0.041, GFI = 0.998, AGFI = 0.991, CFI = 0.980, TLI = 0.950), supporting its adequacy for preliminary path interpretation. The notably low χ^2/df value may reflect the parsimony of the direct effects specification, which involves fewer estimated parameters than the full structural model.

As presented in Figure 3, influencer expertise ($\beta = 0.35$) and content quality ($\beta = 0.31$) demonstrated positive effects on purchase intention (Table 9), suggesting that Generation Z consumers respond favorably to influencers who exhibit domain-specific knowledge and produce high-quality content. In contrast, influencer passion did not demonstrate a meaningful direct effect on purchase intention ($\beta = 0.04$), indicating that emotional enthusiasm alone may not independently drive purchase decisions without accompanying perceived authenticity or value. Frequency of exposure exhibited a negative effect on purchase intention ($\beta = -0.08$), consistent with the content fatigue hypothesis, wherein excessive exposure to influencer content diminishes consumer interest. These preliminary findings informed the specification of the full structural model, which incorporates engagement, trust, and perception as mediating variables to provide a more

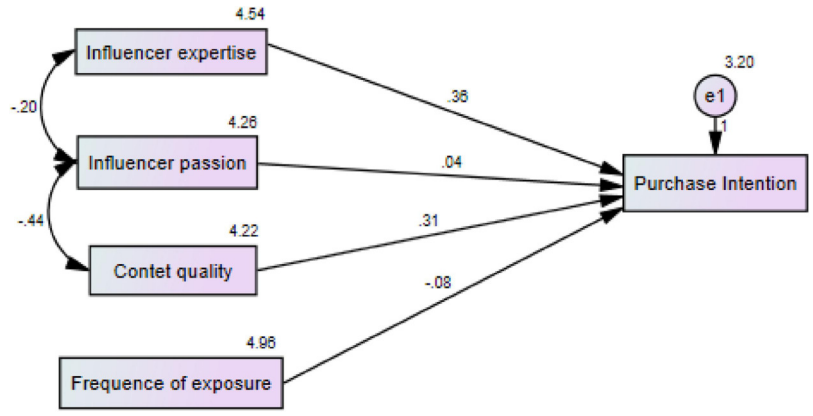


FIGURE 3
Direct effects model – influence of independent variables on purchase intention.

TABLE 9 Standardized direct effects on purchase intention.

Path	Estimate	*p*-value	Supported
IFE → PI	0.36	<0.001	Supported
IFP → PI	0.04	>0.05	Not supported
CQ → PI	0.31	<0.01	Supported
FOE → PI	−0.08	<0.05	Negative effect

TABLE 10 Model Fit indices.

Fit index	Value	Threshold	Interpretation
χ^2/df	1.927	<3	Acceptable
RMSEA	0.050	<0.06	Good
GFI	0.977	>0.90	Excellent
AGFI	0.954	>0.90	Excellent
CFI	0.965	>0.95	Excellent
TLI	0.946	>0.95	Good
PCLOSE	0.462	>0.05	Good fit

comprehensive explanation of influencer marketing effectiveness among Generation Z consumers.

5.3 Structural equation modeling results and hypothesis testing

5.3.1 Hypothesis testing

The full structural model (Figure 4) demonstrated satisfactory to excellent fit across all evaluated indices (Table 10) (χ^2/df = 1.927, RMSEA = 0.050, GFI = 0.977, AGFI = 0.954, CFI = 0.965, TLI = 0.946, PCLOSE = 0.462), supporting the adequacy of the model for hypothesis testing.

Regarding the direct effects (Table 11) on purchase intention, behavioral engagement with influencer content did not demonstrate a significant effect on purchase intention ($\beta = -0.014$, $p = 0.736$), indicating that H1 is not supported. Trust demonstrated a statistically significant positive effect on purchase intention ($\beta = 0.426$, $p < 0.001$), providing support for H2. Consumer perception of influencer authenticity, credibility, and relevance also demonstrated a significant positive effect on purchase intention ($\beta = 0.454$, $p < 0.001$), supporting H3.

With respect to antecedent paths, influencer expertise demonstrated a significant positive effect on trust ($\beta = 0.565$, $p < 0.001$), confirming H4. Influencer passion demonstrated a positive but marginally non-significant effect on engagement ($\beta = 0.093$, $p = 0.056$), falling just above the conventional threshold of 0.05; accordingly, H5 is not supported at the 0.05 significance level. The proposed relationship between influencer passion and trust was also non-significant ($\beta = 0.080$, $p = 0.074$), indicating that H6 is not supported. Content quality demonstrated a significant positive effect on perception ($\beta = 0.534$, $p < 0.001$), confirming H7. Frequency of exposure demonstrated a statistically significant negative effect on perception ($\beta = -0.098$, $p = 0.018$), supporting H8 and indicating that repeated exposure reduces consumer evaluations of influencer authenticity, consistent with the content fatigue hypothesis.

Regarding mediation effects, bootstrapping procedures were employed with 5,000 resamples and bias-corrected 95% confidence intervals. The indirect effect of influencer expertise on purchase intention through trust was positive and significant [$\beta = 0.241$, 95% CI (0.156, 0.334)], supporting H9. The indirect effect of influencer passion on purchase intention through engagement was non-significant [$\beta = -0.001$, 95% CI (−0.018, 0.014)], as the confidence interval includes zero; accordingly, H10 is not supported. The indirect effect of content quality on purchase intention through perception was positive and significant [$\beta = 0.243$, 95% CI (0.158, 0.341)], supporting H11.

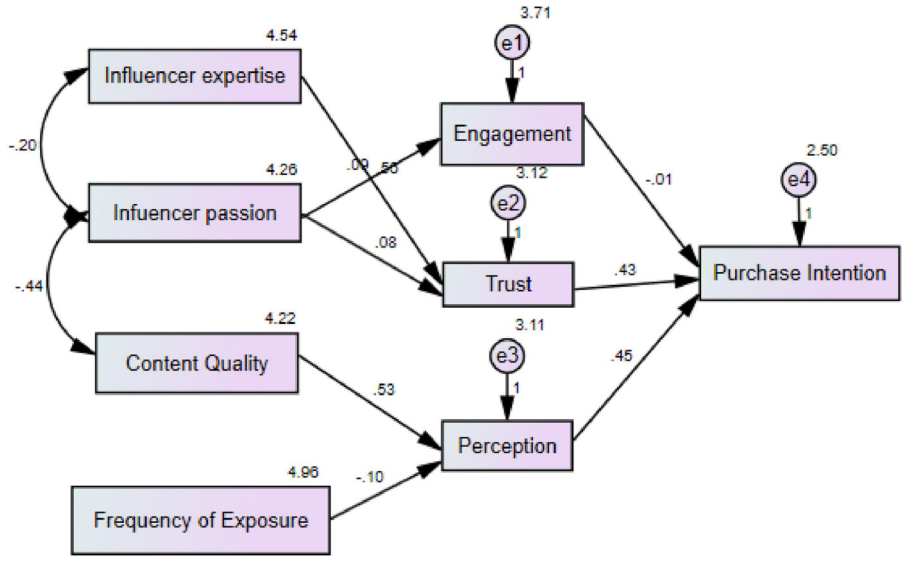


FIGURE 4
Final structural model with mediating variables and standardized estimates.

TABLE 11 Path analysis.

Hypothesis	Path	β	p	Interpretation
H1	Engagement → PI	−0.014	0.736	Not supported
H2	Trust → PI	0.426	<0.001	Supported
H3	Perception → PI	0.454	<0.001	Supported
H4	Expertise → Trust	0.565	<0.001	Supported
H5	Passion → Engagement	0.093	0.056	Not supported
H6	Passion → Trust	0.080	0.074	Not supported
H7	CQ → Perception	0.534	<0.001	Supported
H8	FOE → Perception	−0.098	0.018	Supported
H9	Expertise → Trust → PI	0.241	<0.001	Supported
H10	Passion → Engagement → PI	−0.001	ns	Not supported
H11	CQ → Perception → PI	0.243	<0.001	Supported
H12	FOE → Perception → PI	−0.045	<0.05	Supported

Finally, the indirect effect of frequency of exposure on purchase intention through perception was negative and significant [$\beta = -0.045$, 95% CI (−0.089, −0.012)], supporting H12 and indicating that content fatigue indirectly reduces purchase intention through diminished consumer perception."

6 Discussion of findings

This study provides important insights into how influencer characteristics are associated with the purchase intentions of Generation Z consumers in the Indian context. Consistent with Source Credibility Theory (Ohanian, 1990), the findings indicate that influencer expertise influences purchase intention indirectly through trust. For Indian Generation Z consumers, who are often characterized by skepticism toward overt promotional content, perceived expertise functions as a credibility cue that reduces perceived risk and enhances confidence in influencer recommendation. This finding is particularly relevant in the Indian digital retail environment, where concerns about sponsored content may heighten the role of expertise as a trust-building signal, and is consistent with prior research conducted in Western contexts (Casaló et al., 2020), while extending its applicability to an emerging market setting.

Content quality was also found to influence purchase intention primarily through perception. High-quality, relevant, and visually appealing content enhances consumers' perceptions of influencer authenticity and alignment with brand values. This pattern may reflect central-route processing, as described in the Elaboration Likelihood Model (Petty and Cacioppo, 1986), where individuals rely on message quality when evaluating persuasive communication. However, the non-significant role of engagement as a mediator is particularly noteworthy given that prior studies conducted in Western contexts have generally reported positive engagement effects on purchase intention. This divergence may reflect culturally specific patterns of social media use among Indian Generation Z consumers, who may engage with influencer content primarily for entertainment or information rather than as a precursor to purchase behavior. Additionally, platform-specific factors and the high volume of influencer content in the Indian digital ecosystem may contribute to engagement behaviors that are decoupled from actual purchasing decisions.

The findings further indicate that frequency of exposure negatively affects perception and indirectly reduces purchase intention. This challenges the conventional assumption that increased exposure enhances persuasion. Instead, the results may indicate diminishing responsiveness to repeated exposure, potentially reflecting content fatigue (Reinikainen et al., 2020), particularly when excessive exposure reduces perceived authenticity. In contrast, influencer passion demonstrated only a marginal effect on engagement and no significant relationship with purchase intention. This finding diverges from prior studies (Lou and Yuan, 2019) and suggests that overt expressions of enthusiasm may not consistently translate into perceived credibility within this context. It is possible that such expressions are perceived differently within the Indian cultural context, where audiences may exercise greater scrutiny toward emotionally expressive promotional communication; however, this interpretation remains speculative and warrants further empirical investigation.

Overall, these findings advance theoretical understanding of influencer marketing by demonstrating that different influencer attributes operate through distinct psychological mechanisms. The results further indicate that the effectiveness of influencer marketing is context-dependent, shaped by the preferences and behavioral tendencies of Generation Z consumers in emerging markets.

6.1 Theoretical contributions and insight

First, this study extends the application of Source Credibility Theory (Ohanian, 1990) and Parasocial Interaction Theory (Horton and Wohl, 1956) to the context of Indian Generation Z consumers. While these theories have been widely applied in Western contexts, their relevance within emerging market settings, characterized by distinct cultural norms and digital

consumption patterns, has received comparatively limited attention. By applying these frameworks within the Indian Tier-1 metropolitan context, this study provides empirical evidence of their cross-cultural applicability and highlights the role of contextual factors in shaping influencer effectiveness.

Second, the findings reveal a negative association between frequency of exposure and consumer perception, which indirectly reduces purchase intention. This challenges the traditional assumption of the mere exposure effect (Zajonc, 1968). The results may suggest the presence of diminishing responsiveness to repeated influencer content among Generation Z consumers. While content fatigue is not directly operationalized in this study, the observed negative relationship provides a basis for future research to formally examine this phenomenon as a distinct construct in influencer marketing contexts.

Third, this study advances the influencer marketing literature by integrating multiple influencer attributes specifically "expertise and passion" alongside content-related factors, including content quality and frequency of exposure, within a unified structural framework. Unlike prior studies such as Sokolova and Kefi (2020), which focused primarily on credibility and parasocial interaction, this study examines the differential mediating roles of trust and perception in translating influencer attributes into purchase intention. Notably, while trust and perception emerged as significant mediators, engagement did not significantly influence purchase intention in this context. This suggests that the mediating role of behavioral interaction may be limited among Generation Z consumers in emerging markets.

6.2 Practical and managerial implications

For marketers, brand strategists, and content creators operating in lifestyle-oriented sectors, the findings suggest that strategic emphasis should be placed on domain expertise, credibility, and content quality. Collaborations should prioritize influencers who are not only popular but also perceived as knowledgeable and authentic within their niche.

In addition, brands should carefully manage content frequency. Rather than relying on volume, a strategically timed and curated approach is more likely to sustain consumer interest and trust. Overexposure may lead to disengagement, thereby undermining campaign effectiveness. Maintaining a balance between visibility and value is crucial for long-term impact.

The findings carry several specific practical implications for marketers, influencer agencies, and content creators:

- Prioritize Expertise to Build Trust: Brands targeting Indian Generation Z should collaborate with influencers who demonstrate clear domain knowledge and professional credibility, as trust emerged as a significant and influential mediator of purchase intention.
- Focus on Quality over Quantity: High-quality, relevant content enhances consumer perception and indirectly strengthens purchase intention more effectively than frequent posting.
- Avoid Overexposure: Excessive posting frequency may contribute to content fatigue and diminish brand impact; optimal content schedules should balance visibility with perceived novelty and value.
- Rethink Engagement Metrics: High engagement rates do not necessarily translate into higher purchase intentions; marketers should evaluate the quality of interactions rather than their quantity."

7 Conclusion

This study developed and tested a structural model examining the relationships between influencer attributes, content quality, and Generation Z consumers' purchase intention in the Indian digital retail context. The findings indicate that trust and perception emerged as significant determinants of purchase intention, operating as key psychological mechanisms through which influencer expertise and content quality translate into consumer behavior. In contrast, engagement did not significantly influence purchase intention, and frequency of exposure demonstrated a negative association with perception, which may indicate the presence of content fatigue or diminishing responsiveness to repeated influencer content among Generation Z consumers. These findings highlight the relative importance of trust and perception as the primary mechanisms linking influencer attributes to purchase intention, while suggesting that behavioral engagement metrics may be limited predictors of actual consumer decision-making in this context.

From a theoretical standpoint, this study extends the application of Source Credibility Theory and Parasocial Interaction Theory to the Indian Generation Z context, providing empirical evidence of their relevance within an emerging market setting. By integrating multiple influencer attributes and content-related factors within a unified structural framework, the study advances understanding of how distinct influencer characteristics operate through different psychological pathways to influence consumer behavior.

For practitioners, the findings suggest that influencer strategies should prioritize credibility, authenticity, and content quality over excessive exposure frequency. Brands targeting Generation Z consumers in India are advised to collaborate with influencers who demonstrate domain-specific expertise and produce high-quality, relevant content, rather than relying on high posting frequency to sustain consumer interest. These insights are especially relevant in the current digital ecosystem, where Generation Z consumers exercise considerable selectivity in their engagement with influencer content.

Overall, this study contributes a theoretically grounded and empirically validated understanding of influencer marketing effectiveness among Generation Z consumers in India, offering a foundation for future research to further examine the contextual and cultural factors that shape influencer-driven consumer behavior in emerging markets."

8 Limitations and future research

As with most empirical studies, this research is subject to several limitations that should be considered when interpreting the findings.

First, the study employs purposive non-probability sampling confined to Tier-1 metropolitan cities in India, which restricts the

generalizability of the findings. The sample primarily represents digitally active urban consumers; therefore, the results may not be applicable to Generation Z populations in rural areas or different socio-economic contexts. Future research should adopt probability-based sampling techniques and include more geographically diverse segments to improve representativeness.

Second, the use of a cross-sectional research design limits the ability to establish causal relationships among variables. While the model assumes directional relationships, alternative explanations cannot be ruled out. For instance, it is equally plausible that pre-existing trust influences perceptions of influencer expertise, indicating the possibility of reverse causality. Future research may adopt longitudinal or experimental designs to address this limitation.

Third, as all variables were measured using self-reported data collected at a single point in time, the study is susceptible to common method bias (CMB). Although procedural remedies such as ensuring respondent anonymity were applied, no formal statistical tests (e.g., Harman's single-factor test) were conducted to assess the extent of CMB. Future studies are encouraged to incorporate both procedural and statistical techniques to mitigate this issue.

Fourth, while trust and perception were modeled as distinct constructs, there is potential conceptual overlap between them, which may raise concerns regarding discriminant validity. Although statistical tests support construct validity, future research could further refine the operationalization of these constructs to ensure clearer conceptual separation.

Fifth, the study focuses on influencer marketing within the fashion and food sectors, primarily on platforms such as Instagram and YouTube. This limits the applicability of the findings to other industries and platforms, where influencer dynamics and user engagement patterns may differ substantially. Future research could extend the model to alternative domains to enhance external validity. Furthermore, the weak effect of influencer passion on engagement and purchase intention may reflect platform-specific and expression-related factors not captured in the current study. Future research could examine how different modes of emotional expression across platforms such as Instagram Reels and YouTube Shorts influence the persuasive effectiveness of influencer passion among Generation Z consumers.

Sixth, while quantitative methods have provided structural insights into influencer marketing effectiveness, future research could employ qualitative approaches — such as in-depth interviews or case studies — to explore the subjective dimensions of influencer authenticity and content fatigue in greater depth, providing richer contextual understanding of the psychological mechanisms identified in this study.

Finally, the findings are situated within the Indian cultural context, which may influence consumer perceptions and responses to influencer marketing. Future research could adopt cross-cultural comparative approaches, including multinational comparative studies, to examine how socio-cultural factors shape the effectiveness of influencer attributes and mediating mechanisms, thereby enhancing the generalizability of the findings.

Data availability statement

The raw data supporting the conclusions of this article will be made available by the authors, without undue reservation.

Ethics statement

Ethical approval was not required for the study involving humans in accordance with the local legislation and institutional requirements. Written informed consent to participate in this study was not required from the participants or the participants' legal guardians/next of kin in accordance with the national legislation and the institutional requirements.

Author contributions

KM: Conceptualization, Data curation, Formal analysis, Methodology, Software, Writing – original draft. NA: Supervision, Validation, Visualization, Writing – review & editing.

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The author(s) declared that this work was conducted in the absence of any commercial or financial relationships that could be construed as a potential conflict of interest.

Generative AI statement

The author(s) declared that generative AI was not used in the creation of this manuscript.

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Appendix A: Survey Instrument Scales

All items were measured on a 5-point Likert scale (1 = Strongly Disagree to 5 = Strongly Agree).

- Independent Variables

Influencer Expertise (IFE) (Adapted from Casaló et al., 2020; Ohanian, 1990)

- **IFE1:** The influencer is highly knowledgeable in their domain.
- **IFE2:** The influencer provides reliable and accurate information.
- **IFE3:** The influencer is experienced in food/fashion content.

Influencer Passion (IFP) (Adapted from Lou and Yuan, 2019)

- **IFP1:** The influencer shows genuine passion for what they promote.
- **IFP2:** The influencer appears enthusiastic and invested in their content.
- **IFP3:** Influencer seems emotionally connected to their niche.

Content Quality (CQ) (Adapted from Djafarova and Trofimenko, 2019; Hwang and Zhang, 2018)

- **CQ1:** The content is visually appealing and professionally produced.
- **CQ2:** The influencer shares high-quality and creative posts.
- **CQ3:** The content is consistent and relevant to my interests.

Frequency of Exposure (FOE) (Adapted from Reinikainen et al., 2020)

- **FOE1:** I frequently see this influencer's posts on my feed.
- **FOE2:** The influencer posts content regularly.
- **FOE3:** I often engage with the influencer's posts (likes, comments, shares).
- Mediating Variables

Engagement (ENG) (Adapted from Jin et al., 2019)

- **ENG1:** I like, comment, or share this influencer's content regularly.
- **ENG2:** I actively follow updates from this influencer.
- **ENG3:** I enjoy interacting with the influencer's content.

Trust (TT) (Adapted from Ohanian, 1990; Sokolova and Kefi, 2020)

- **TT1:** I trust the information shared by this influencer.
- **TT2:** The influencer appears honest and transparent.
- **TT3:** I believe this influencer has my best interests in mind.

Perception (PP) (Adapted from Audrezet et al., 2020)

- **PP1:** I can relate to this influencer personally.
- **PP2:** The influencer reflects values and lifestyle similar to mine.
- **PP3:** I view the influencer as authentic and genuine.
- Dependent Variable

Purchase Intention (PI) (Adapted from Sokolova and Kefi, 2020)

- **PI1:** I would consider buying a product recommended by this influencer.
- **PI2:** I have already bought products based on this influencer's suggestion.
- **PI3:** I am likely to try a product if this influencer promotes it.

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